reaction. I again shouted: “Erich!” This time with “Red Front!” That rang across the whole courtyard … Again nothing.’ (There is anecdotal evidence that Mielke was trying to work his passage out of the dock by feigning senility. However, the record shows serious questions were asked as to whether the former Stasi chief was sufficiently balanced or emotionally stable to stand trial.)

When defence lawyer Nicolas Becker met Honecker a week later, he saw a man with a fighting spirit which:

stayed on until he had the opportunity to give his long political statement in this trial, although this spirit was increasingly restrained by his failing health. My impression was that communist leaders were best to bear when they were not in power, during their fighting period. Honecker, in the early phase of his stay in Moabit, showed a bit of the fighting spirit of a communist youth leader.

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An unexpected source of comfort was provided by a former schoolteacher, Eva Ruppert, who made contact with Erich after seeing a report about his incarceration on TV. Over the coming months, she visited Moabit five or six times and kept up a vigorous flow of correspondence. ‘He never complained about his situation, but showed great humanity,’ she recalled, though was astonished at how he had visibly aged. Even in a tracksuit, she thought he ‘retained poise and dignity’. Erich took some consolation from reading, writing and from music and – at his request – Ruppert sent books and cassette tapes (music by Vivaldi and spoken Rosa Luxemburg works). He was impressed with bestsellers Bonfire of the Vanities by Tom Wolfe, The Firm by John Grisham,7 and Heleno Saha’s Fourth Reich, which he thought, ‘excellently written’. Eva also sent a copy of Memories, Andrei Gromyko’s newly published autobiography. ‘Now I am starting to read it